

Small Group Bible Study Series

Galatians 1:18-2:10

Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches

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① The Text	② Devotional	③ Commentary	④ Self-Study Guide
<i>Foundation</i>	<i>Personal prep</i>	<i>Leader / Teacher</i>	<i>Group together</i>
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① THE BIBLICAL TEXT

NKJV · Read together before anything else

Galatians 1:18-24

18 *Then after three years I went up to Jerusalem to see Peter, and remained with him fifteen days.*

19 *But I saw none of the other apostles except James, the Lord's brother.*

20 *(Now concerning the things which I write to you, indeed, before God, I do not lie.)*

21 *Afterward I went into the regions of Syria and Cilicia.*

22 *And I was unknown by face to the churches of Judea which were in Christ.*

23 *But they were hearing only, "He who formerly persecuted us now preaches the faith which he once tried to destroy."*

24 *And they glorified God in me.*

Galatians 2:1-10

1 *Then after fourteen years I went up again to Jerusalem with Barnabas, and also took Titus with me.*

2 *And I went up by revelation, and communicated to them that gospel which I preach among the Gentiles, but privately to those who were of reputation, lest by any means I might run, or had run, in vain.*

3 *Yet not even Titus who was with me, being a Greek, was compelled to be circumcised.*

4 *And this occurred because of false brethren secretly brought in (who came in by stealth to spy out our liberty which we have in Christ Jesus, that they might bring us into bondage),*

5 *to whom we did not yield submission even for an hour, that the truth of the gospel might continue with you.*

6 *But from those who seemed to be something—whatever they were, it makes no difference to me; God shows personal favoritism to no man—for those who seemed to be something added nothing to me.*

7 *But on the contrary, when they saw that the gospel for the uncircumcised had been committed to me, as the gospel for the circumcised was to Peter*

8 *(for He who worked effectively in Peter for the apostleship to the circumcised also worked effectively in me toward the Gentiles),*

9 *and when James, Cephas, and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived the grace that had been given to me, they gave me and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship, that we should go to the Gentiles and they to the circumcised.*

10 *They desired only that we should remember the poor, the very thing which I also was eager to do.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Heart preparation · read in the days before your group meets

“There is one Gospel, and it's all of grace, all of God. The ground is level at the cross.”

Paul kept a meticulous, sworn account of every trip he made to Jerusalem — “before God, I do not lie” (1:20). That mattered because the Judaizers were suggesting his gospel had really come from Jerusalem's blessing. It hadn't. Paul's independence from human approval wasn't pride; it was precision, protecting a gospel that belonged to Christ alone.

When Paul finally did return to Jerusalem years later, he didn't go to get his message checked or corrected. He went to carry relief to hungry believers, and only along the way — almost as an aside — did he compare notes with the leaders there, to be sure they were laboring toward the same goal, not working against each other.

When pressure came to add just one requirement to simple faith — in this case, circumcision for Titus — Paul would not yield, “not even for an hour.” And the very apostles some assumed would side against him instead recognized the same grace at work in him that was at work in Peter, and gave him the right hand of fellowship. One gospel. One grace. Level ground for everyone who comes to the cross.

Reflect:

1. Where might you feel pressure to seek human approval for something God has already made clear to you?
2. Is there a “just this one thing” you've been tempted to add to simple faith in Christ — for yourself, or for someone you're discipling?
3. “The ground is level at the cross.” How does that truth change how you view people you consider more — or less — spiritual than yourself?

Lord, thank You for one gospel, freely given, with nothing left for me to add.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

Proposition: Paul's gospel and apostleship were independent of, and never subordinate to, the churches and leaders in Jerusalem — a fact confirmed not by Paul's own claim alone, but by the Judean churches' own testimony and the Jerusalem apostles' own recognition.

Introduction: Five Visits to Jerusalem

The text today has to do with five times in which Paul went to Jerusalem. Now, we know that not only from Galatians, but also from the book of Acts, which we studied prior to this study. So the book of Acts gives us five Jerusalem visits. They are, first of all, the visit after he left Damascus. And we see that recorded in Acts 9, 26-30, but also in Galatians 1, 18-20, which is part of our text today. The second visit is the famine visit in Acts 11, 27-30, and then in Galatians 2, 1-10, which we'll cover today as well. And then he visited after that. He visited for the Jerusalem Council in Acts 15. We read about that. That's the longest record that we have of his time in Jerusalem. And then he visited, at the end of his second missionary journey, he went up and just greeted the church, then went back up to, down to Antioch. And then finally, he went to Jerusalem and it was there that he was taken into custody. Remember, in the temple, they took him into custody. And he didn't get out of there until after he had gone through Caesarea, two years. And then in Rome, it was two years in prison. Now, those are the times he went to Jerusalem.

I. Paul's Early Travels — 1:18-24

Now, we want to start out with Paul's early travels. This is going to involve the visit where he left Damascus. He went to Jerusalem, as we'll see.

A. Paul's First Post-Conversion Visit to Jerusalem — 1:18-20

Now, first he says, We're looking now at verse 18. If you have your Bibles, you may turn to Galatians chapter 1, verses 18 to 21. Now, he says, After three years, now after three years, I think it to be, after three years after his conversion, he went down to Jerusalem to see Peter and remain with him **five days**. But I saw none of the other apostles except James the Lord's brother. So this is after his conversion. Here's what Acts says about it. Let me read this to you. And when he had come to Jerusalem, remember, he's been persecuting the church. Everywhere he went, he'd find people who were in the church and he'd haul them off to Jerusalem and he would put them in jail, kill them. Didn't matter. They didn't like the people who were Christians. And He's been doing all that. But then in Acts 9, verses 26-28 says, And when he had come to Jerusalem, he attempted to join the disciples, after he got saved now. He'd been persecuted in the church, now he's one of them. So he comes and he attempts to join the disciples. I want to come in and worship with you. And they were all afraid of him, with good reason. And they did not believe that he was a disciple. But Barnabas, remember Barnabas, son of consolation, He took him and brought him to the apostles and declared to them how on

the road he had seen the Lord who spoke to him, and how at Damascus he had preached boldly in the name of Jesus. So he went in and out among them in Jerusalem, preaching boldly the name of the Lord. That's where he went. And then verse 20, he makes a parenthetical affirmation. Parenthetical affirmation is, what I'm writing to you is truth. I'm not leaving anything out. This is all the times I went out there, and I am telling you the truth before God. Look what he says, verse 20, Now concerning the things which I write to you, indeed, before God I do not lie. Now, if he's trying to tell them that all the times he went to Jerusalem, if he left out one visit, wouldn't that be lying? This is the only time that I went. Oh, I don't mention one. He lied. So he's saying, here, no, I'm telling you the truth. So this is a list of all the times he had been to Jerusalem. So he's taken a solemn oath before God. And this is important because he's telling them all the times. And so if he leaves one out, we're in trouble. This has to be then, his record in chapter 2, it has to be the famine visit of Acts 11:28-30. Now, don't worry about that. We're going to talk about that a little bit more as we go along. Now, the visit to Jerusalem for the council that settled the law and grace dispute, you know what that is? Acts 15. This is later on. It's going to be about, oh, from 48 to 50, it's going to be about two years. Later, there will be a council in Jerusalem. And some people think that Acts 15 is talking about that council visit, where they had a discussion about the grace gospel and they settled it. Salvation is by grace through faith plus not one thing. You don't do anything. You believe on Jesus, you have eternal life. So they got that settled in A.D. 49 or 50. So if Paul is talking about that, at the end of that time, they wrote a letter. At the end of Acts 15, they wrote a letter and said, Here is our decision. And they said, Greetings of the letter, and then they said, Farewell at the end. It was a letter. And that letter they wrote for the churches in Galatia or anywhere else, all the Gentile churches, I want you to see this. And that letter, do you think Paul had a copy of that in his hip pocket? Of course he did. After all, he was the apostle to the Gentiles. So I take it then, if this had been later on at the Acts 15 council, Paul would have simply ripped it out and said, here, see what the apostles said? See what they said in Jerusalem? It says here, it's by grace through faith plus nothing. You don't have to be circumcised in order to be saved. So all I'm saying there is, this is not A.D. 49 or 50, he's talking about in A.D. 48, not 49 or 50.

B. Paul's Ministry in Syria and Cilicia — 1:21

All right, so Paul's ministry in Syria and Cilicia, 21. He said afterward, after that, I went to the region of Syria and Cilicia. Now, he was doing great. He was preaching the gospel in Jerusalem doing a fine time that we read that a while ago. Now, in chapter 9 verses 29 and 30, Paul's still in Jerusalem. and he spoke and disputed against the Hellenists. Does that sound familiar? He spoke and disputed against the Hellenists, that is, the Greek Christians or the Greek Jews. Well, yeah, Stephen did that. What happened to Stephen? They stoned him. They killed him. Well, Paul did that. Paul was there, by the way, agreeing to that killing of Stephen. Now he's doing the same thing. What do you think is going to happen? Well, he spoke and disputed against the Hellenists, but they were seeking to kill him, just like they did Stephen, Acts 7. Then when the brothers learned, that is the Christian brothers, learned this, they brought him down to Caesarea and sent him off to Tarsus. He's talking about now, I was there, then I went off to Tarsus.

C. Paul's Relation to the Church in Jerusalem — 1:22-24

Now, then in verses 22 to 24, Paul's relation to the church in Jerusalem after that.

1. They Did Not Know Him by Face — 1:22

They did not know him by face, he says, verse 22. I was still unknown by face to the churches of Judea that were in Christ. They didn't know. If he could walk down the street in Jerusalem, they wouldn't know him by face, most of them.

2. They Heard That He Was Preaching the Faith — 1:23

And they heard that he was preaching the faith, verse 23, they heard that. And they were hearing only, 'He who formerly persecuted us now preaches the faith,' which he once tried to destroy.

3. They Were Praising God for Paul's Conversion — 1:24

And they were praising the Lord for Paul's conversion. It was wonderful that they glorified God in me. There is rejoicing in heaven when one person comes to know Jesus Christ. There was rejoicing in heaven last Friday night. Scott came to know the Lord. Yeah, that's what happens. Well, they were rejoicing because of that. Now, instead of fighting against us, this man is fighting for us. He's with us. Isn't that great? 31, we're reading this to picture what he just said. So the church throughout all Judea and Galilee and Samaria had peace and was being built up. And walking in the fear of the Lord and the comfort of the Holy Spirit, it multiplied. That's what happens. That's what happens when you walk in the fear of the Lord, and when you walk in the comfort of the Holy Spirit, looking only to Jesus, only to the Lord for your guidance, that's when you multiply. Now, multiply is not getting bigger. Multiplying is getting more people. But that's what he says happened, because they were walking in fear of the Lord, and they were walking in the comfort of the Holy Spirit.

II. Paul's "Famine" Visit to Jerusalem — 2:1-10

So that's Paul's early travels, and that's a buildup to Paul's next visit, a visit to Jerusalem, which is his famine visit, chapter 2 verses 1 to 10, and that's the major thrust of what I want to say today. Now, this is a historical record of this visit is found in Acts 11. Paul says, after 14 years I went up to Jerusalem. Well, when was that? Well, we find that in chapter 11 of Acts, 27 to 30. Here's what it says: In these days, prophets came from Jerusalem to Antioch, and one of them, named Agabus, one of those prophets named Agabus, stood up and showed by the Spirit that there was going to be a great famine throughout all the world, which also happened in the days of Claudius Caesar. Then the disciples, each, according to his own ability, determined to send relief to the brethren dwelling in Judea. This they also did, and sent it to the elders, and then the elders distributed it to the church, but they sent it by the hands of Paul and Barnabas. So Paul is saying, I went to Jerusalem. Why did you go, Paul? I went there on this famine visit to take what gifts the Antioch Church had gotten together, take them to Jerusalem, to the elders, and the elders distributed it into the church. Here's something here, that the church is helping another church. We are responsible for each other, for one another, and they were taking this very seriously. There's a problem in Jerusalem. The famine has caused them to have need. They sent the need there. But they didn't send it just to give it to the mayor of Jerusalem. They gave it to the church. They didn't even give it to the poor people in the church. They gave it to the church, and the church distributed it to people who needed it, and to people who deserved it. You mean people have to deserve? Well, what does Paul say? Paul says, If a man will not

work, what? Let him go hungry. Don't let him eat. See, that's why you give it to the elders. The elders took the money. They know who's working, who's trying, whatever. They're doling it out in that way. I threw that in there because some people feel, well, the church has to pay, has to give money to everybody that comes by. We got them here. Oh, brother, I've got my car out here and I'm out of gas and my wife is in the car. I want to get up to North Carolina where I live and I just need \$5 to get some gas. You won't get out of the county with that anymore. There's a little money for gas. I've heard every one of them, he wants a gallon, he doesn't want a gallon of gas and a fish. What I'm saying to you is that the church is not responsible to feed everybody in Broward County. Our responsibility is to our brothers. That's not in my notes, but I think it's very important for us to see that we're not responsible to save the world. We're not responsible to feed the world. It's not our responsibility. Oh, well, your church, your church, you're supposed to do that. No, church, we're supposed to take care of our own. Anyway, that's my little heresy for today.

A. The Representatives of the Visit to Jerusalem — 2:1-2

Now, the representatives on that visit to Jerusalem are here.

1. The Time — 2:1a

The time was 14 years later. There was much controversy here over this phrase, after 14 years. Some people say, well, it's 14 years from his last visit to Jerusalem. And they hold to a later writing for Galatians. More likely, he's talking about 14 years after Paul's conversion. So I'm going with the latter, though there are a lot of good reasons for the other, and it doesn't make a whole lot of difference. So I'll talk more about that a little bit. That's the time, 14 years after Paul's conversion.

2. The Team — 2:1b

And then the team that went. He said, I went up to Jerusalem with Barnabas and took Titus with me. Now Paul was the leader. Paul was the leader of the team. He took Barnabas, he says Barnabas was with me, and Barnabas was with him on the famine visit. We read that in the book of Acts chapter 11. He was on the third missionary journey, on the first missionary journey as well. And then Titus, this is the first mention of Titus in the book. You can look back and see that. But Titus is first mentioned here. He went with them, and Titus was a Gentile, not a Jew, so uncircumcised.

3. The Text — the Gospel That Paul Preached

Now, the text, the thing that they discussed when they got there was the gospel that Paul preached. It is a gospel of grace. And that's the whole thing. See, when you hear me talking about the gospel of grace, you say, that's all you talk about. It's important. It's important for us to know that salvation, your salvation, you need to know that yourself, that my salvation was not from anything I did. Not one thing. God didn't look down and say, Well, there's a rib. I think I'll... no, there wasn't a rib. I'll take old Norm here. He's such a good person. I want him. He lives a good life and never sinned in his life. Don't believe that one. Ask Melanie. No. No, not that. There's old Norm down there. He's a scoundrel. He was in the Navy two years. What do you think, you know? He is not fit for anything. But I know what I can do with him. What I'm going to do is I'm going to take him out of that and I'm going to set him up. I'm giving him eternal life and

I'm going to train him to serve me. Why? By God's grace. He didn't deserve it. Neither did you. See, so it's important to hold on to this grace gospel. That's the gospel that Paul preached. Those are the representatives.

B. The Reason for the Visit (assuming the “famine visit”) — 2:2

Now the reason for the visit, it's for the famine relief.

1. It Was in Response to a Revelation — 2:2a

It was in response to a revelation. Remember that from the Acts passage, he said, I went up by revelation. Well, 27 says, Agabus gave a revelation there would be a famine, especially in Jerusalem, and they were not summoned by the church. In other words, Paul didn't go to Jerusalem because somebody said, Hey, I want you to come up here and explain what your gospel was. No, not that at all. He was there to take the famine relief to the church. And let's see in a minute what else happens.

2. It Was a Private Meeting — 2:2c

Then it was a private meeting, he says, I went up privately. That means it wasn't a council, it wasn't a public meeting there, and there wasn't any public response, and all that. It wasn't that. It was private.

3. It Was a Chance for Paul to Discuss His Gospel — 2:2b

And then it was a chance for Paul to discuss his gospel. Listen to this. He says, I went up there and that word “and” is important — and communicated to them the gospel which I preached among the Gentiles. Notice the “and.” He does not say, I went up there to talk about my gospel. No, I went up there and while I was there I discussed my gospel. It was that important. He discussed it with those who were of reputation, the apostles, lest by any means I might run, or had run, in vain. Now, that's a strange place. You know, I spent more time on this sermon than most sermons. I mean, I went over and over and over on this, trying to say, Now, what does that mean? Well, Paul didn't question — when he talked to those apostles, lest I might have run in vain — Paul wasn't there to say, Do you think my gospel is right? No, no. Where had he gotten his gospel? From the Lord. You can't beat that. See, he wasn't up there to do that. He wasn't there to find out if the gospel was right. What he was trying to do is to find out the relationship between the gospel he was preaching and the gospel they were preaching. What are you people doing? What are you doing in Jerusalem, so we'll be on the same page? He's going to do that. What are you doing here? See, if they were insisting on circumcision and law-keeping for Christians, for Gentiles, then Paul was running in vain. I can't fight against that. I'm out here preaching, and they say, Well, Jerusalem says you have to do this. No, Paul says, No, my Gospel says you don't have to do that. So he's up there to get them on the same page with him. So Paul then would be running in vain, at least running uphill.

C. The Disruption of the Visit — 2:3-10

So we had the representation. We also had the reason. Now we have the disputation of the visit. This is the last seven verses, four through 10.

1. The Ruse of the False Brothers — 2:4-5

First we have the ruse of the false brothers, the excuse they gave for what they were doing. Verses four and five.

a. They Slipped into the Meeting — 2:4a

It says, They slipped into the meeting. This occurred because the false brothers secretly brought in, who came in by stealth. That's verse 4a. They came in by stealth. They didn't belong there. And they were there under false pretenses. They came into a meeting that was supposed to be a private meeting with just a couple of apostles, but they came in seemingly to find out, oh, yes, we want to find out what this is, too. They didn't believe that. They knew what it was all about. And they were trying to throw the monkey wrench into Paul's plans.

b. They Spied Out Our Freedom — 2:4b

They slipped in and they spied out the freedom. They were just there to find out, what are you saying? I wish somebody would come in and spy on our freedom. I like to have a lot of people coming in and say, what do you mean by that? I trust the word of God. I trust that gospel. The gospel is the power of God unto salvation. I don't mind if people come in and whatever they want to do, but these people found the gospel there, I think, too, didn't believe it. All right, so in verse 4b, they came in to spy out our Liberty, which we have in Christ Jesus. What do you mean by Liberty? Liberty, we hear the gospel, now what do you have to do? I hate to keep bringing Scott up, but I'm going to do it one more time. I said to Scott, you ought to be in church Sunday. Has nothing to do with your salvation. I want to make sure he understands that. You don't have to come to church. What you do, you ought to, and we're glad to have you. See, that's important for us to do that. Separate all the things that you should do from all the things that you have to do. What's all the things you have to do? Believe. All these other things that you should do are over here, and we'll get to those later, but not now, not when you're presenting the gospel. The gospel is simply Liberty. And that's what they were going to spy out. They were going to spy out our liberty, which we have in Christ, that they might bring us into slavery. A lot of people were out to do that today. You'll find out, people will say, You'll believe, all you have to do is believe. As Ray says on the website, We really believe. That's all you have to do is believe. There's no such thing as really believing, by the way. You believe. There's no, Oh, I'm going to believe. You believe. Either you believe it or you don't. It says, They are trying to spy out our liberty and bring us back into slavery but then you also have to do this and this and this. No. They were there to infiltrate and then to bring us into slavery. They didn't tell them why they were there. Two purposes, two-fold purpose, to spy out the liberty of grace, and then to bring them into the slavery of the law. You must keep the law.

c. They Sought to Have Titus Circumcised — 2:3

Well, how do they want to achieve these goals? Well, they sought to have Titus circumcised, verse 3. Notice I dropped back because verse 3 can't be understood until you get 4. So now I'm back to 3. They sought to have Titus circumcised. He says in verse 3, Yet not even Titus, who was with me, being a Greek, was compelled to be circumcised. They wanted to. Oh, this guy's going to be circumcised. And Paul said, no, sir. The apostles agreed with him. No, sir, we don't have to do that. So that was their roots. They wanted to set a precedence. We got Titus. He came with Paul. If we can get him, Titus, to be circumcised, then we have the precedence, Paul allowed one of his cohorts to be circumcised. Therefore, it's necessary. And Paul said, No way. I'm not going to do that. Because you see, if you add one thing to the gospel, it's bad. One thing.

And that one thing, see, can multiply to be many things, but that's not the point. The point is, if you add one thing to the gospel, you have made it a false gospel. One thing, it's a false gospel. And what did Paul say about this false gospel? If any man brings to you any other gospel, then that which I preach to you, let him be accursed. And again, I say to you, he says it again, I say to you, even if we or an angel should come in here and preach any other gospel, Let him be accursed. So it's very serious. Don't bring one thing. And Paul said, No, sir, not that one.

2. The Response of Paul — 2:5

Now, what's the response of Paul? Verse 5, it says, To whom we did not yield submission even for one hour. We didn't let those guys even get a foothold in, that the truth of the Gospel might continue with you. And the truth of the Gospel is it is by grace through faith, plus not one thing. Don't yield. Don't yield on anything, is what he's saying.

3. The Reaction of the Apostles — 2:6-10

Now, reaction of the apostles, what are they going to say? Here's Paul saying to these agitators, these Judaizers, no, he's not going to be circumcised. But all the apostles were circumcised, all the Jews in Jerusalem who believed had already been circumcised before they believed. What are they going to say? I wonder if that ran through Paul's mind. He mentions it here in verse 6.

a. They Added Nothing to Paul's Gospel — 2:6

He says, But in verse 6, they added nothing to Paul's gospel. He says, But those who seem to be something, whatever they were, it makes no difference to me, God shows personal favoritism to no man. See, the first part of verse 6 sounds as though Paul's mad at the apostle, doesn't it? Who they were, I don't know who they were. He's not mad at them. He's just saying to you, these Judaizers, if they quoted an apostle, or maybe even misquoted, if they came to you and said, The apostles say you ought to do this, you have to be circumcised in order to be saved. Well, they might have misquoted. But even if they did say it, even if an apostle said that, guess what? That doesn't make it right, because God doesn't accept anybody's person. Nobody is above God's Word, no matter who they are. That's His point. God doesn't show personal favor to them. See, heresy is heresy wherever you find it. It's heresy even if it comes from somebody wearing a fancy suit or a long robe or a funny hat, you know, or has 10 degrees after his name. What's a degree anyway? I had mine a while. I don't have to worry about that. You tell him who just got his degree and probably didn't do anything for it. Call me doctor. No, I'm a doctor. Signs his name, doctor. The man was introduced one time, and the man introducing him hadn't gotten all the facts. So he started, here's my preacher. He's been preaching here and here and here. And he said, brother, what are your degrees? And the man said, degrees? What do you think I am, a thermometer? It doesn't matter. It doesn't matter where he's been or what he's done. The gospel is the gospel, and heresy is heresy no matter where it comes from. And then he says, for those who seem to be something added nothing to me. Again, that sounds a little bit defensive. And it's not that. He's saying, they didn't add a thing to my gospel. Paul's gospel says, by grace through faith, plus not one thing. They didn't add one thing to that. That's what he's saying.

b. They Recognized That Paul's Gospel Was the Same as Peter's — 2:7

And they also recognized that Paul's gospel was the same as Peter's gospel. This is great. He says, On the contrary, when they saw that the gospel for the uncircumcised had been committed to me as the gospel for the circumcised was to Peter. In other words, Peter's going to the Jews, I'm going to the Gentiles. When they saw that, the major difficulty was that the Jews were already circumcised, as I mentioned. They were already circumcised. And to some, that meant circumcision was necessary. It's like if most people were saved in a church, or a lot of people — I'm looking back a ways, but in my early days, everybody was saved in the church. In fact, if somebody told the gospel to those people, they would say to them, now come to church next Sunday, come forward so you can be saved. No. If you believe, you believe anywhere. You're already saved. So some people think, well, they were saved in the church, then you might get the idea you have to believe on Jesus and join the church. Because everybody did that. It was just one thing you did. Not true. The fact that you were saved in the church doesn't mean a thing any more than if you were saved wherever. That's all I'm saying. So these Jews were already circumcised because they were Jews. Of course they were. Then they thought that that had to be. No. The answer to the question, to the Jew or to the Greek — if a Jew comes to you and says, What must I do to be saved? If a Gentile comes to you and says, What must I do to be saved? The answer is the same. there's only one gospel, to the Jew, to the Gentile, to the barbarian, to the Scythian, bond or free, male or female, the gospel is one. That's what he's saying. So the answer to the question, what must I do to be saved? What did Paul say? Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ and you will be saved, Acts 16:31.

c. They Recognized the Same Power at Work in Both — 2:8

So they also recognized the power in both Peter and Paul was not their own power. Look what it says. For he who worked effectively in Peter for the apostleship to the circumcised also worked effectively toward the Gentiles, in me. So the same power that worked in Peter was the same power working in Paul. It's one church. It's one salvation. It's one gospel, no matter from whom it comes, so that one power. It's the power of God. Now, remember what Paul said in 1 Corinthians where he says, I planted, and Apollos watered. Oh, isn't that wonderful? Big Paul, big Apollos. Then the next verse he says, And all the while, God was giving the increase. See? That's it. Apart from the power of God, see, the Gospel is the power of God to salvation. It isn't me. It isn't you. It isn't this church or that church. It's the power of God working through the Gospel as we present it to someone.

d. They Gave Paul the Right Hand of Fellowship — 2:9

He says, When James and Peter and John, who seemed to be pillars, perceived the grace that had been given to me, they gave me and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship. That's a great thing. You're one of us and we're together. We'll do this thing together. And that they should go to the Gentiles and Peter should go to the circumcised. They go separate ways, to separate people, but with the same gospel. That's what he's saying.

e. The Apostles Requested That They Should Remember the Poor — 2:10

Then the apostles requested that they should remember the poor. This is almost laughable, you know. What had Paul come there for? To bring money for the poor. Oh, Paul, remember the poor. Oh, duh. I just did it. But Paul said, I'm used to doing that, of course. So, one thing to leave out. He says, remember the poor. But there's nothing here about things strangled and things and blood. In Jerusalem Council, at the end of that, in the letter, they said, You Gentiles,

remember the poor, but also stay away from things strangled and away from blood, drinking blood, ceremonially, you know, false religions. That's not here. That's why I say this is not the Jerusalem Council he's talking about.

Conclusion

Now, the key teaching here is this. There is one Gospel. Now, I know, why am I laboring it here? Well, because we need to be reminded of it. There is one Gospel and it's all of grace, all of God. The ground is level at the cross. Have you ever heard anybody say that? I think Billy Graham said it first, to my knowledge. At the cross, when you come to the cross, it isn't oh, the Pharisees are up here on this high plain, you know. They're right close to God. No, the ground is level. And when you come, you stand on the same level I do. And I stand on the same level as everybody else, you know, and you do too. The ground is level. And no matter who you are, no matter whom you approach, you can say this to them, you only have to do one thing. **They leave** on the Lord Jesus Christ and you'll be saved. This is a great passage for that. We're going to learn more about that in this book.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Grammar	Definition & Significance
v.18	ἱστορέω (ἱστορήσαι) to visit / become acquainted with	Strong's G2477 historēsai Verb · Aor. Act. Inf.	ATR: To inquire into or interview; here, to visit for the purpose of coming to know someone personally. <i>Significance in context: Paul's stated purpose was acquaintance, not instruction — he did not go to be taught the gospel by Peter.</i>
v.20	ψεύδομαι to lie, speak falsely	Strong's G5574 pseudomai Verb · Pres. Mid./Pass. Dep. Ind. · 1st Sg.	STR: To utter an untruth, deceive by lying. <i>Significance in context: Paul's oath underlines that his account of Jerusalem visits is complete, not selective — his credibility as an independent apostle rests on it.</i>
v.22	ἄγνοέω (ἀγνοούμενος) to not know / be unknown	Strong's G50 agnooumenos Verb · Pres. Pass. Ptc. · Nom. Sg. Masc.	THAY: To be ignorant of; passive, to be unknown to someone. <i>Significance in context: Paul was a stranger by sight to the Judean churches — further evidence he did not minister under their supervision.</i>
v.24	δοξάζω (ἐδόξαζον) to glorify, honor	Strong's G1392 edoxazon Verb · Imperf. Ind. Act. · 3rd Pl.	VINE: To ascribe honor and praise, especially to God for His work. <i>Significance in context: the churches glorified God, not Paul — his transformation was received as evidence of grace, not a personal achievement.</i>
v.2	ἀνατίθημι (ἀνεθέμην) to lay before, declare for consideration	Strong's G394 anethemēn Verb · Aor. Mid. Ind. · 1st Sg.	MRV: To set forth or refer a matter to another for consideration or judgment. <i>Significance in context: Paul laid his gospel before the Jerusalem leaders to confirm agreement, not to seek their verdict on its truth.</i>
v.4	ψευδάδελφος false brother	Strong's G5569 pseudadelphous Noun · Acc. Pl. Masc.	THAY: One who ostentatiously professes to be a Christian brother but lacks true faith. <i>Significance in context: these were infiltrators posing as believers — opposition to grace sometimes wears the language of the church.</i>
v.4	κατασκοπέω (κατασκοπήσαι) to spy out, examine treacherously	Strong's G2684 kataskopēsai Verb · Aor. Act. Inf.	STR: To inspect closely with hostile intent, as a spy. <i>Significance in context: their interest in Paul's gospel was reconnaissance aimed at undoing it, not honest inquiry.</i>
v.4	ἐλευθερία freedom, liberty	Strong's G1657 eleutherian Noun · Acc. Sg. Fem.	VINE: The state of being free from bondage — here, freedom from the law as a means of righteousness.

Verse	Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Grammar	Definition & Significance
			<i>Significance in context: this is the very liberty every believer possesses the moment they trust Christ alone, and precisely what the false brothers wanted to take away.</i>
v.4	καταδουλόω (καταδουλώσουσιν) <i>to enslave, bring into bondage</i>	Strong's G2615 <i>katadoulōsousin</i> Verb · Fut. Ind. Act. · 3rd Pl.	THAY: To reduce to bondage, bring under complete subjection. <i>Significance in context: adding law-keeping to grace does not improve the gospel — it enslaves those who receive it.</i>
v.6	λαμβάνω πρόσωπον <i>to show partiality (lit. "receive the face")</i>	Strong's G2983 / G4383 <i>lambanei prosōpon</i> Verb + Noun · Pres. Ind. Act. / Acc. Sg. Neut.	STR: πρόσωπον — the face, outward appearance; the idiom denotes judging by external status. <i>Significance in context: God's evaluation of anyone's standing never depends on titles, reputation, or rank — protecting the gospel from being overruled by status.</i>
v.7	πιστεύω (πεπίστευμαι) <i>to believe; (pass.) to be entrusted</i>	Strong's G4100 <i>pepisteumai</i> Verb · Perf. Pass. Ind. · 1st Sg.	ATR: Perfect passive — a settled, completed state of having been entrusted, with continuing effect. <i>Significance in context: Paul's mission to the Gentiles was a trust given by God, recognized — not granted — by the Jerusalem apostles.</i>
v.9	κοινωνία <i>fellowship, shared partnership</i>	Strong's G2842 <i>koinōnias</i> Noun · Gen. Sg. Fem.	THAY: Association, community, joint participation. <i>Significance in context: the "right hand of fellowship" signals shared standing in the same gospel — a full partnership, not a franchise of Jerusalem's authority.</i>
v.10	πτωχός (πτωχῶν) <i>poor, destitute</i>	Strong's G4434 <i>ptōchōn</i> Adj. (subst.) · Gen. Pl. Masc.	STR: Reduced to beggary, utterly destitute. <i>Significance in context: care for the poor was the one thing Jerusalem asked of Paul — a practical fruit of grace, not a doctrinal addition to it.</i>

Grammar Abbreviation Key

Category	Abbreviations
Cases (Nouns / Adj.)	Nom. (Nominative) · Gen. (Genitive) · Dat. (Dative) · Acc. (Accusative) · Voc. (Vocative)
Number	Sg. (Singular) · Pl. (Plural)
Gender	Masc. (Masculine) · Fem. (Feminine) · Neut. (Neuter)
Verb Mood	Ind. (Indicative) · Imp. (Imperative) · Subj. (Subjunctive) · Opt. (Optative) · Inf. (Infinitive) · Ptc. (Participle)

Category	Abbreviations
Verb Tense	Pres. (Present) · Imperf. (Imperfect) · Fut. (Future) · Aor. (Aorist) · Perf. (Perfect) · Plpf. (Pluperfect)
Verb Voice	Act. (Active) · Mid. (Middle) · Pass. (Passive)
Verb Person / Number	1st Sg. / 1st Pl. · 2nd Sg. / 2nd Pl. · 3rd Sg. / 3rd Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Commentary Point	Reference
I. Paul's Early Travels	1:18-24
II.A-B. The Famine Visit: Representatives & Reason	2:1-3
II.C. The Disruption: False Brothers & the Apostles' Response	2:4-10

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Why does Paul take a “solemn oath” (v. 20) about his account of visiting Jerusalem, and why does it matter for dating the events of Galatians 2?

Leader Answer: Paul is swearing that his account of every Jerusalem visit is complete. That completeness is what allows us to identify the visit in Galatians 2 as the famine visit of Acts 11, not the Jerusalem Council of Acts 15 — if the Council had already happened, Paul would surely have cited its decision.

2. Paul says he went to Jerusalem “by revelation” (2:2) and discussed his gospel almost as an aside (“and communicated...”). What does this order of events protect?

Leader Answer: It protects the fact that Paul's gospel didn't originate with, or depend on, Jerusalem's approval. He went for famine relief; discussing his gospel was incidental to that trip, not the reason for it — the opposite of what the Judaizers implied.

3. What two-fold purpose did the false brothers have in Galatians 2:4, and how does καταδουλόω (“to enslave”) describe the stakes?

Leader Answer: They wanted to spy out believers' liberty in Christ and then bring them into bondage by requiring circumcision. καταδουλόω means to reduce completely to slavery — showing that adding one requirement to grace doesn't improve the gospel, it enslaves those who receive it.

4. Why does Paul say “those who seemed to be something added nothing to me” (2:6), and what does that phrase protect against?

Leader Answer: It confirms the Jerusalem apostles didn't supplement, correct, or improve Paul's gospel in any way — protecting against any claim that Paul's message was really Jerusalem's message in disguise, or that it needed apostolic amendment to be complete.

5. The apostles asked Paul to “remember the poor” (2:10) — the one request they made. Why is it significant that this request was practical rather than doctrinal?

Leader Answer: It shows the only thing “added” to Paul's gospel mission was a call to compassion, not a new doctrinal requirement — confirming that the gospel itself remained untouched, by grace through faith alone, while still expecting genuine care for others as its fruit.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verses	Focus	Summary
1:18-24	Independent Ministry	Paul's early travels show him ministering apart from, and largely unknown to, the Judean churches — evidence his gospel was not derived from them.
2:1-3	A Deliberate Visit	Paul returned to Jerusalem by revelation, not summons, to bring famine relief — and only secondarily discussed his gospel with the leaders there.
2:4-6	Resisting Compromise	False brothers tried to force circumcision on Titus to establish a law-keeping precedent; Paul refused to yield, even briefly.
2:7-10	Full Recognition	The Jerusalem apostles added nothing to Paul's gospel, recognized the same grace and power at work in him as in Peter, and extended full fellowship.

⑤ APPLICATION

Personal and corporate response — draws from all sections above

A Gospel That Answers to God, Not to Committees

Scripture: *Galatians 1:18-24*

Source: *Commentary §I; Devotional*

Paul's early ministry unfolded largely apart from, and unknown to, the very churches some assumed had authorized him. Our confidence in the gospel does not depend on human certification either — it rests on what God has revealed and already validated in changed lives.

Reflection: Where do you look for validation of your faith — to human approval, or to what God has already done and said?

Practical Step: This week, thank God specifically for one piece of evidence of His grace in your life that no one else gave you credit for.

Bring the Relief, Discuss the Gospel Along the Way

Scripture: *Galatians 2:1-2*

Source: *Commentary §II.A-B*

Paul's trip to Jerusalem was first an act of practical compassion — famine relief for suffering believers — and only secondarily a theological conversation. Grace-shaped ministry often looks like showing up to serve first, with gospel clarity following naturally out of relationship.

Reflection: Is there a person or need in front of you right now that simply needs practical care before it needs a theological conversation?

Practical Step: Identify one practical need you can meet this week for someone in your church family, without waiting for a “spiritual” reason to do it.

Not Yielding, Not Even for an Hour

Scripture: *Galatians 2:3-6*

Source: *Commentary §II.C; Self-Study Guide (καταδουλόω, ἐλευθερία)*

When pressure came to add just one requirement to faith, Paul didn't negotiate, delay, or compromise “for an hour.” The truth of the gospel — grace alone, through faith alone — was worth that firmness.

Reflection: Where might you be tempted to soften or qualify the simplicity of “believe and you will be saved,” even with good intentions?

Practical Step: Practice stating the gospel this week in one sentence, with nothing added to “believe.”

The Ground Is Level at the Cross

Scripture: *Galatians 2:7-10*

Source: *Commentary §II.C; FGR.docx — Charles C. Ryrie, So Great Salvation: What It Means to Believe in Jesus Christ (Wheaton: Victor Books, 1989)*

Peter and Paul went to different peoples with the same gospel, under the same grace, empowered by the same God — proof that no status, background, or calling changes the terms of salvation. Ryrie's classic Free Grace study makes the same case for today's reader: the gospel is one, and it is level ground for everyone who comes to it.

Reflection: Is there anyone you unconsciously treat as needing a “different,” harder path to God than the one you walked?

Practical Step: Identify one person you've mentally placed on different spiritual footing than yourself, and pray this week that you'd see them as standing on the same level ground at the cross.

End of Study · Galatians 1:18-2:10